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Economics - Asia Pacific/Asia ex-Japan

Chipnomics #3: The boom continues, chipflation follows

Upward CSI revisions point to tighter chip supply and a stronger boom, with chipflation pressures likely to persist into 2027.

Research Analysts

Asia Economics

Jeong Woo Park - NSL
jeongwoo.park@nomura.com
+65 6433 6197

Si Ying Toh, CFA - NSL
siying.toh@nomura.com
+65 6433 6666

- **The Nomura Chip Shortage Index (CSI) eased marginally to 104.0 in October from an upwardly revised 104.1 in September.** October's modest CSI decline reflects historical upward revisions rather than an easing shortage. Upward revisions to July-September suggest supply conditions were tighter than previously estimated.
- **The CSI clock remains firmly in the boom phase**, with a higher level and broadly steady positive momentum, offering little evidence of a cyclical turning point.
- **Semiconductor export prices continued to rise in September.** Our analysis of the relationship between the CSI and chip prices points to further price gains through year-end.
- **Nomura CSI as an early warning indicator for chipflation:** Our empirical analysis finds that the CSI leads consumer electronics inflation by around 8 months in Korea and 11 months in Taiwan.

Historical revisions outweigh October's modest decline

The Nomura Chip Shortage Index (Nomura CSI; Bloomberg ticker: NMRCSI index) eased marginally to 104.0 in October from an upwardly revised 104.1 in September (Figure 1). However, we view this easing as a technical decline rather than a fundamental easing in semiconductor shortages.

CSI readings from July through September were revised higher, with particularly large upward revisions to August (+0.47pt) and September (+0.25pt). This raised the comparison base for October, making the latest estimate appear softer on a month-on-month basis. The revisions lift the Q3 average by around 0.33pt, indicating that semiconductor shortages were more pronounced than previously estimated.

Thus, while the headline CSI has eased from its revised August peak, the latest update does not suggest a fundamental turn towards looser supply-demand conditions.

The CSI clock signals a stronger boom

The CSI clock remains firmly in the boom phase (Figure 2), and its latest position suggests that the upswing has strengthened relative to the previous month. Taken together, the revised CSI readings and the CSI clock provide little evidence of a meaningful easing in supply-demand conditions.

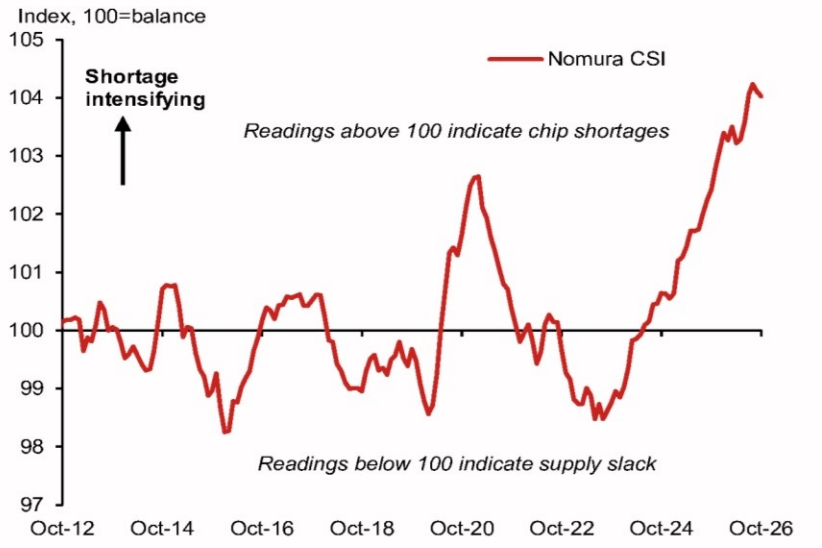
Chip prices remain on track for further gains

Meanwhile, semiconductor export prices maintained their upward momentum in September. Based on our analysis of the relationship between the CSI and semiconductor prices, persistent shortages should continue to support price gains through year-end. The latest update thus reinforces our view that chip pricing remains on an upward trajectory, despite the modest decline in October's headline CSI reading.

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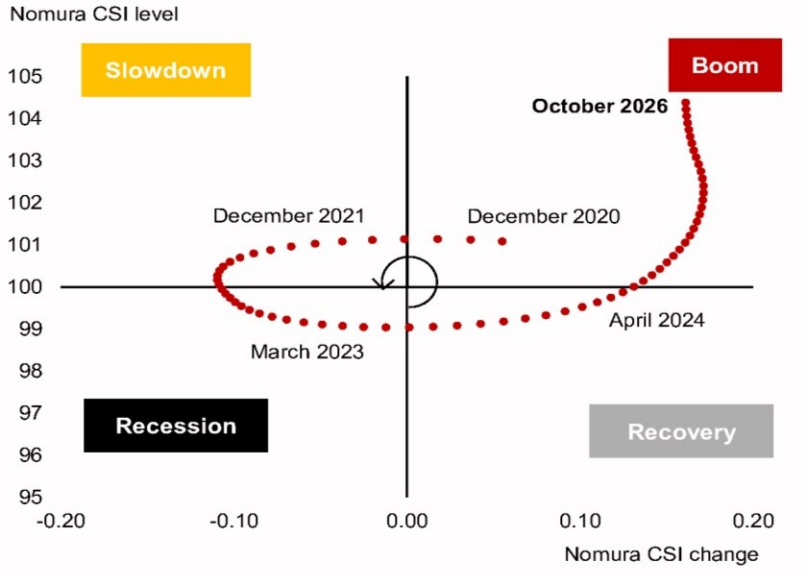
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Fig. 1: Nomura's Chip Shortage Index (Nomura CSI)



Note: Nomura's chip shortage index (Nomura CSI) can be found on Bloomberg (see ticker: NMRCSI Index). Nomura CSI tracks the balance between chip demand and supply each month. Readings above 100 signal shortage while readings below 100 signal supply slack. Changes in the index show whether the demand-supply imbalances is intensifying or easing. The CSI is subject to revisions reflecting revisions of its sub-components. For more details, see *Special Report: Introducing Nomura's Chip Shortage Index* (19 August 2026).
Source: CEIC, Bloomberg and Nomura Global Economics.

Fig. 2: Nomura CSI clock



Note: We apply the Hodrick-Prescott (HP) filter to the original Nomura CSI to extract its underlying trend, then classify the cycle into four regimes based on the trend's level (supply tightness) and its month-on-month change (momentum).
Source: CEIC, Bloomberg and Nomura Global Economics.

Key developments in the Nomura CSI dashboard

Chip shortage persists despite tentative supply improvement

The latest dashboard (Figure 3) suggests that the semiconductor market remains deeply supply-constrained, although some indicators point to tentative easing at the margin. Supply conditions have improved modestly, but demand remains very strong, while memory prices continue to hover near record highs. Taken together, the data suggest that the chip shortage cycle has yet to reach a turning point.

On the supply side, there are signs of improvement, but the recovery remains uneven. Korea's chip production growth edged up to 1.4% y-o-y in August from just 0.3% in July, while its chip inventory-to-shipment ratio declined from 0.56 to 0.51. Korea's electronics production BSI also rebounded to 110 in October, its highest reading since

August 2022. Taiwan's electronics production PMI eased to 60.0 in September from 63.7 in August, suggesting some moderation in production momentum, although activity remains firmly expansionary. Overall, the improvement in supply indicators remains modest relative to the strength of demand.

Demand remains robust, although some forward-looking indicators have moderated at the margin.

Big-tech capex growth expectations eased from a peak of 138.6% y-o-y in August to a still-elevated reading of 130.6% in October. Taiwan's ICT export orders expanded by a solid 87.3% y-o-y in September, though this is a moderation from 100.5% in August.

Korea's electronics new orders BSI rose to 110 in October, its highest reading since August 2022. Meanwhile, Taiwan's electronics PMI new orders index fell from 67.5 in August to 56.7 in September, which is nonetheless in expansionary zone.

Overall, demand indicators suggest that chip demand is still strong, even though the pace of acceleration may be moderating in some segments.

AI-specific indicators also point to an interesting divergence between falling inference costs and resilient compute demand. The token expenditure index declined from 1.9 in May to 1.0 in October. However, this does not imply weaker underlying AI demand, as lower token prices may reflect efficiency gains, technological improvements and intensifying competition among model providers. Cheaper inference could, in turn, stimulate greater AI usage and demand for computing resources. Indeed, the GPU rental index increased to 2.8 in October from 2.7 in September, suggesting that demand for AI computing capacity remains resilient despite declining inference costs.

Memory prices continue to provide strong evidence of tight market conditions

Korean DRAM export prices rose 247.7% y-o-y in September, broadly unchanged from 249.2% in August, while NAND export-price inflation eased slightly from 246.4% to 244.0%. Meanwhile, DDR5 prices increased further to USD50.5 in October from USD49.3 in September, reaching a new high and more than doubling from their Q4 2025 level. The persistence of exceptionally strong price increases suggests that the supply-demand imbalance remains substantial, despite tentative improvements in production and inventories.

Overall, the dashboard points to continued chip scarcity, rather than a turn in the cycle. Some demand indicators have eased modestly and supply is gradually responding, but AI-related capital spending remains exceptionally strong and memory prices continue to rise.

Fig. 3: Nomura CSI dashboard

	2023		2024		2025				2026							
	H1	H2	H1	H2	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	Q1	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct
Supply																
Chip production, % y-o-y (Korea)	-23.6	24.9	34.2	12.2	13.2	16.5	23.1	0.2	10.3	13.3	1.5	1.8	0.3	1.4	-	-
Chip inventory to shipment ratio (Korea)	1.75	1.39	0.96	0.93	0.76	0.61	0.48	0.51	0.53	0.52	0.56	0.51	0.56	0.51	-	-
Electronics production BSI (Korea)	74.3	70.5	77.2	92.8	86.3	96.7	90.0	93.0	95.0	97.0	95.0	103.0	104.0	100.0	103.0	110.0
Electronics PMI production index (Taiwan)	46.1	46.5	55.4	53.5	54.4	57.9	46.2	54.5	60.8	70.0	69.2	66.7	65.8	63.7	60.0	-
Electronics inventory to shipment ratio (US)	2.26	2.24	2.25	2.20	2.14	2.13	2.13	2.11	2.04	2.02	2.01	1.97	2.00	2.01	-	-
Demand																
Big tech capex market estimates, % y-o-y	11.0	6.6	18.8	37.8	56.4	65.8	62.6	79.2	89.1	102.5	105.5	127.4	133.6	138.6	132.1	130.6
ICT export orders, % y-o-y (Taiwan)	-12.4	-11.5	-0.5	9.4	15.5	37.4	26.0	61.9	92.7	89.7	67.2	81.9	89.5	100.5	87.3	-
Electronics PMI new orders index (Taiwan)	42.6	45.0	56.4	53.2	54.1	55.9	44.1	53.3	65.0	69.5	70.1	66.7	67.3	67.5	56.7	-
Electronics new orders BSI (Korea)	67.3	63.5	79.8	93.3	88.3	96.7	91.0	96.3	93.3	97.0	95.0	99.0	107.0	107.0	108.0	110.0
Token expenditure index	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	1.5	1.7	1.9	1.8	1.5	1.1	1.0	1.0
GPU rental index	-	-	-	2.5	2.1	2.3	2.1	2.0	2.4	2.5	2.6	2.7	2.7	2.7	2.7	2.8
Prices																
DRAM export price, % y-o-y (Korea)	-45.8	-34.3	25.2	46.7	11.7	0.7	5.4	42.3	129.2	223.1	236.6	238.2	240.0	249.2	247.7	-
NAND export price, % y-o-y (Korea)	-50.0	-18.0	90.0	72.0	-28.6	-29.9	-27.4	41.6	148.2	161.5	202.3	229.5	219.6	246.4	244.0	-
DDR5 price, USD	-	4.1	4.2	4.4	4.4	4.9	5.3	20.8	33.0	31.4	35.4	42.3	46.8	49.7	49.3	50.5

Note: For big tech capex market estimates, we use 12-month forward Bloomberg consensus estimates for four big tech companies, namely Microsoft, Amazon, Google and Meta. Green cells denote tighter supply, stronger demand and higher prices. Red cells denote higher supply, weaker demand and lower prices.
Source: Bloomberg, CEIC and Nomura Global Economics.

Nomura CSI as an early warning indicator – Inflation edition

Chipflation could last through 2027

Beyond tracking semiconductor scarcity, the Nomura CSI also provides a potentially useful leading signal of consumer electronics inflation. Our analysis suggests that the CSI leads Korea's mobile phone and computer CPI inflation by around 8 months, and Taiwan's

educational equipment and goods CPI inflation (our proxy for consumer electronics inflation) by around 11 months (Figures 4 and 5).

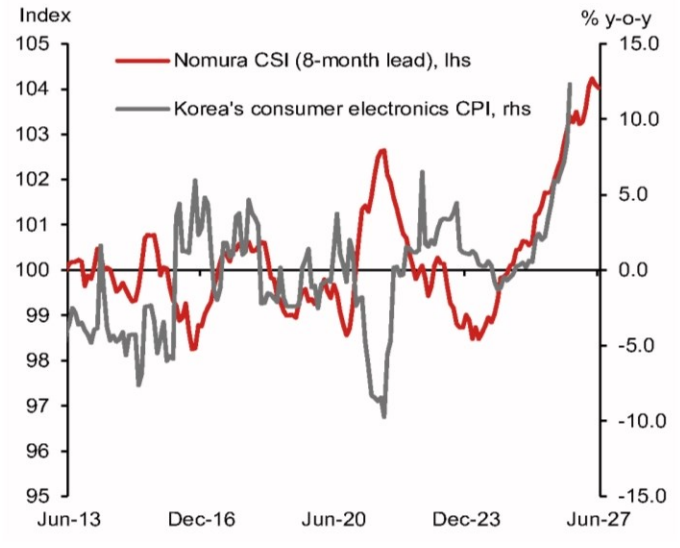
These leads are considerably longer than the two-month lead observed for exports and machinery investment in our previous analysis (see *Chipnomics #2: An intensifying chip shortage is extending the boom phase*, 22 September 2026), suggesting that semiconductor shortages transmit to the broader economy at different speeds.

The transmission mechanism is intuitive. Semiconductors are a key input into consumer electronics, and persistent chip shortages raise production costs for downstream manufacturers. Pass-through to retail prices takes time, reflecting existing inventories, procurement contracts, production cycles, and firms' pricing decisions.

This is consistent with our analysis on chipflation (see *Chipflation in Asia*, 21 October 2026), which shows that consumer electronics inflation has accelerated sharply in Asia, particularly in Korea and Taiwan, with computers experiencing greater price pressures than mobile phones due to their higher exposure to memory costs.The Nomura CSI adds a forward-looking dimension, suggesting that the inflationary effects of semiconductor shortages can persist beyond the initial tightening in chip markets.

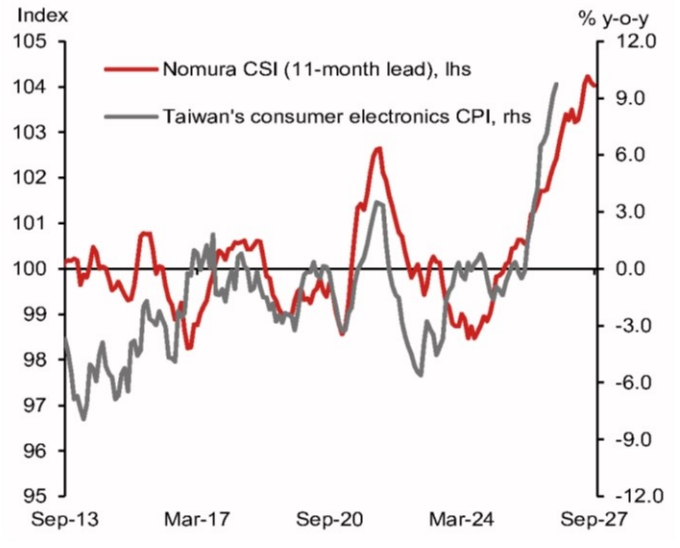
With the CSI remaining firmly in shortage territory, the historical lead-lag relationships point to a risk of continued upward pressure on consumer electronics prices well into 2027, even if semiconductor shortages begin to ease.

Fig. 4: Korea: Nomura CSI versus consumer electronics CPI



Note: For Korea, consumer electronics CPI refers to mobile phone and computer CPI. The CSI is shifted forward by eight months to illustrate the historical lead-lag relationship. The extended CSI line does not represent our CPI forecasts.
Source: CEIC and Nomura Global Economics.

Fig. 5: Taiwan: Nomura CSI versus consumer electronics CPI



Note: For Taiwan, we use educational equipment & goods CPI as a proxy for consumer electronics CPI. The CSI is shifted forward by eleven months to illustrate the historical lead-lag relationship. The extended CSI line does not represent our CPI forecasts.
Source: CEIC and Nomura Global Economics.

What about 2027 and beyond?

We had previously highlighted that our analysis suggests that the shortage-led upcycle could sustain higher chip prices for longer than in past cycles. With the current upturn having begun in H2 2025, our model points to gains through 2027 and beyond (see *Special Report – Chipnomics: Introducing Nomura's Chip Shortage Index*, 19 August 2026). This is consistent with our tech team's bottom-up view. Our tech analysts highlighted a 75% likelihood that the semiconductor supercycle would persist, as the AI race is likely to continue (see *The unstoppable race*, 23 October 2026), and that the AI infrastructure build-up would surge into 2027, though there is no clarity on 2028 yet (see *AI data center build-up tracker*, 26 October 2026).

Related research reports

Asia insights – Chipnomics #2: An intensifying chip shortage is extending the boom phase, 22 September 2026

Special Report – Chipnomics: Introducing Nomura's Chip Shortage Index, 19 August 2026

Special Report – Korea: When chips meet housing – Two supercycles reshaping the economy, 20 November 2025

Appendix A-1

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